Reading and Using the Literature

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Where we are

Last week

- A thesis is a question you answer
- Who · where & when · outcome · variation · evidence
- Maybe this week you thought about a one-sentence question + three papers

Today

1. What an academic article is, and how it gets published
2. How to read one
3. Finding the literature
4. Judging quality – including predatory journals
5. Turning reading into a literature review

What the literature does for you

1. **Tells you whether your question is new**
   Has it been answered? For this place, period, population, data?
2. **Tells you what to expect**
   What have others found? That gives you hypotheses – and tells you which result would be surprising.
3. **Shows you how to do it**
   Which data did they use? Which method? Which problems did referees make them fix? You can borrow all of this.

Expect your question to change

Reading will narrow it, sharpen it, or show it's already answered.

How an article gets published



Peer review means experts other than the authors checked the work before publication.

In economics, submission to publication often takes years.

Not all sources are equal

Source	Good for	Be careful
Peer-reviewed article	The core of your review	Check the journal (later today)
Review article	Fast map of a whole field	Can be several years out of date
Working paper	The newest results	Not yet peer reviewed; findings may change
Theses & dissertations	Local settings, data sources, methods	Quality varies widely
Reports (FAO, World Bank, BFAP, government)	Context, statistics, policy detail	Usually not peer reviewed; may have a mandate
News, blogs, Wikipedia	Finding leads	Never the source you cite for a claim

If a working paper you cite is later published, cite the published version.

Anatomy of an applied economics paper

Section	Answers. . .
Abstract	The whole paper in 150 words
Introduction	Question, approach, findings, contribution
Background / literature	Context; who did what before
Data	Who, where, when, how measured
Model / strategy	How they get from data to answer
Results	What they found
Robustness	Does it survive other choices?
Conclusion	What it means; limitations

The introduction is the paper

A good economics introduction usually has five parts:

1. **Hook** – why care
2. **Question**
3. **Antecedents** – closest prior work
4. **Value added** – what's new here
5. **Roadmap**

Head, "The Introduction Formula" (online note).

You do not read a paper from start to finish

Pass 1 · 10 minutes

Title, abstract, introduction, section headings, conclusion. Glance at figures and tables.

Decide: is this relevant? Keep or drop.

Pass 2 · about an hour

Read the data and method sections. Study the main tables and figures carefully. Skip the maths.

Decide: what's the main result, and do I believe it?

Pass 3 · several hours

Every section, including the appendix. Check each assumption. Could you redo it with your data?

Only for the 3–5 papers closest to your thesis.

Adapted from Keshav (2007), "How to Read a Paper," *ACM SIGCOMM Computer Communication Review*.

After Pass 1, you should be able to answer

1. What is the **question**?
2. **Who, where, when** – what data?
3. What **method**? What is compared with what?
4. What is the **main finding**? (sign and size)
5. What do the authors claim is **new**?

Sound familiar?

Questions 1–3 are the five things a thesis-sized question names, from last week.

Use the same lens on other people's papers that you use on your own.

If you can't answer these after the introduction, the problem may be the paper, not you.

Reading a results table

Table 3. Contract farming and farm income

	Log farm income	
	(1)	(2)
Has supply contract	0.231***	0.142***
	(0.048)	(0.051)
Farm size (ha)		0.018**
		(0.007)
Other controls	No	Yes
Observations	1,204	1,204
R^2	0.06	0.21

Std. errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$

[These numbers are made up.]

1. **Column header** = the outcome (Y).
2. **Coefficient** = how Y changes with X. Read the *sign* and the *size*.
3. **(Brackets)** = precision. Stars summarise it.
4. **Across columns**: the estimate falls when controls are added. Why? Larger farms get contracts *and* earn more.

Statistically significant $\neq$ economically important.

Exercise (5 minutes): Pass 1 on one of your papers

Take **one** of the three papers you brought.

1. Read only: title, abstract, introduction, conclusion, and the main table.
2. Write down the five answers from the previous slide.
3. Note: **journal name** and **year**. You'll check the journal later today.

Last minute: tell a neighbour, in two sentences, what the paper found.

No paper with you?

Pair up with someone who has one, or open the most recent issue of *Agrekon* and pick any article.

Where to search

Databases

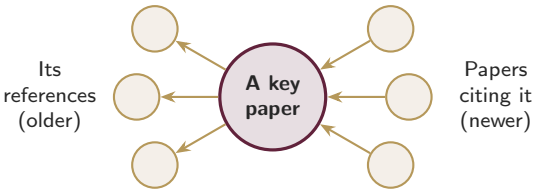
- **Google Scholar** – broad, fast, shows "cited by"
- **Scopus** and **Web of Science** – via the SU Library; curated, better filtering
- **AgEcon Search** – free working papers & conference papers in agricultural and applied economics
- **RePEc / IDEAS** – economics working papers
- **SUNScholar** – SU theses (find local data and methods)

Journals worth knowing

- *Agrekon*
- *African Journal of Agricultural and Resource Economics*
- *American Journal of Agricultural Economics*
- *Journal of Agricultural Economics*
- *Agricultural Economics*
- *Food Policy*
- *World Development*

Don't pay for a paper! If you email the author, a lot of times, they'll send it tod you, if you don't have access to the journal!

Search strategy: start small, then snowball



1. Find 1-2 recent, well-cited papers close to your question (or a review).
2. **Backward**: read their reference lists.
3. **Forward**: click "cited by" to find newer work.
4. Repeat with the best new finds.

When to stop

When new searches keep returning papers you already have.

What is a predatory journal?

A journal that charges authors to publish but provides little or no genuine peer review, and misleads about its standards, indexing, editors, etc.

Why it matters to you as a reader

- Results have not been checked – they may simply be wrong
- Citing them weakens your argument

Why it matters to you as an author

- Publishing there can damage your CV
- Once published, it usually cannot be withdrawn and resubmitted elsewhere

Note: charging a publication fee is *not* the problem – many good open-access journals do. The problem is charging for a review that doesn't happen.

Warning signs

The approach

- Flattering, unsolicited email inviting you to submit
- Promises of acceptance or publication within days
- Fees not stated clearly, or revealed only after acceptance

The journal

- Name that closely imitates a well-known journal
- Very broad scope (“agriculture, science and engineering”)
- Editorial board you can’t verify
- Invented metrics in place of a real impact factor

The papers

- Poor editing; obvious errors left in
- Topics far outside the journal’s stated field
- No described peer-review process
- Claims to be indexed, but isn’t

One sign alone proves little. Several together should make you check carefully.

A five-minute check

1. **Is it indexed?** Look the journal up in *Scopus* or *Web of Science* yourself – don't trust the journal's own claim. For open-access journals, also check *DOAJ*.
2. **Is it the real journal?** "Hijacked" journals copy a real journal's name. Check the website address matches the one listed in the index.
3. **Who publishes there?** Do people whose work you respect publish in it? Have your supervisor or the library heard of it?
4. **Use a checklist**: *Think. Check. Submit.* (thinkchecksubmit.org)
5. **Read the paper itself.** Even in a good journal, judge the data and method.

Beall's well-known list of predatory publishers closed in 2017; archived copies are out of date. Don't rely on any single list.

This happens here, too

Mouton & Valentine (2017)

Studied South African papers that qualified for government research subsidy, 2005–2014.

Found **4,246 papers** in **48 journals** they classified as probably or possibly predatory, with the sharpest growth after 2011.

South African Journal of Science 113(7/8). Both authors were at SU's Centre for Research on Evaluation, Science and Technology (CREST).

Lessons

- Being on an accredited or indexed list is a useful first check – not proof of quality.
- Researchers at good universities get caught too.
- The best protection is reading the paper critically.

A literature review is not a list of summaries

× Organised by paper

Smith (2018) studied contract farming in Kenya and found higher incomes. Jones (2020) studied outgrower schemes in Ghana and found no effect. Dlamini (2021) studied contracts in Limpopo and found mixed results...

The reader has to do the thinking.

[These aren't real papers.]

✓ Organised by idea

Studies of contract farming in sub-Saharan Africa disagree on income effects (Smith 2018; Jones 2020). The difference appears to depend on whether studies account for which farmers are offered contracts (Dlamini 2021). Few studies use South African panel data...

You have done the thinking – and set up your gap.

Tool: the synthesis matrix

Paper	Setting	Data	Method	Main finding	Relevance to me
Author A (year)	Country, crop, years	Survey, $n =$ ...	Comparison used	Sign & size	Same question, other country
Author B (year)	...	...	...	...	Data source I could use
Author C (year)	...	...	...	...	Method to borrow

Fill it in after Pass 1 or 2 – one row per paper. A spreadsheet is fine.

Read it down the columns, not across the rows: where do findings agree? Which settings or data are missing? Those patterns are your review's themes – and your gap.

From the literature to your contribution

Common kinds of gap

- **Setting**: known elsewhere, not here
- **Data**: new or better data
- **Method**: a more credible comparison
- **Conflict**: studies disagree – why?
- **Time**: has something changed since?

A template sentence

Studies of _____ have found _____ (refs). However, _____. This thesis _____.

Be careful with "no one has studied this"

It is a strong claim, and usually means the search isn't finished. Prefer: "few studies have examined..." or "to our knowledge, no study has used...".

Cite honestly – and check every reference

Citing

- Cite what you have actually read. If you only saw it cited elsewhere, say so ("as cited in").
- Paraphrase in your own words *and* cite. Quotation marks for anything copied.
- Take notes in your own words – it prevents accidental plagiarism later.
- Use a reference manager (e.g. Zotero, Mendeley).

AI tools

- AI chat tools can produce references that look real but don't exist, or misstate what a real paper found.
- Open every source you cite. Check the DOI, the journal, and that the paper says what you claim.
- Check SU's and your supervisor's rules on using AI tools.

Questions?

Further reading: Keshav (2007), "How to Read a Paper"; Head, "The Introduction Formula"; Mouton & Valentine (2017), *S Afr J Sci* 113(7/8); Think. Check. Submit. (thinkchecksubmit.org).